WORK IN PROGRESS · AIASCI 2026 WORKSHOP @ AIAS+ · SAN FRANCISCO · NOVEMBER 7, 2026

Evaluating Scientific Agents for Reliable Laboratory Monitoring

LiveLab 1.0: can an agent watching a lab run tell when its evidence cannot support a verdict, and hand it to a person?

Key finding. Asked whether a condition can be verified, models say no and then rule anyway: 7 abstentions in 2,134 judgements, on simulated and real plant data. Stating the scoring rules in the task brought three models to the gate on the simulated set, one run each.

Dekun Sun · University of Pennsylvania, MAS-CS · Founder, ai4s.fyi

github.com/dekunsun/livelab

01 · DEFINE THE FAILURE THAT MATTERS

False reassurance is the error to guard against, not a missed alarm

Every update, a monitoring agent makes two judgements: **is something wrong**, and **is the evidence enough to decide alone**. Four errors, unequal costs.

> **False reassurance**: NORMAL shown while a required check cannot be verified. It removes the reason to go and look. At 1 % per update, about 44 % of two-hour runs are hit at least once.

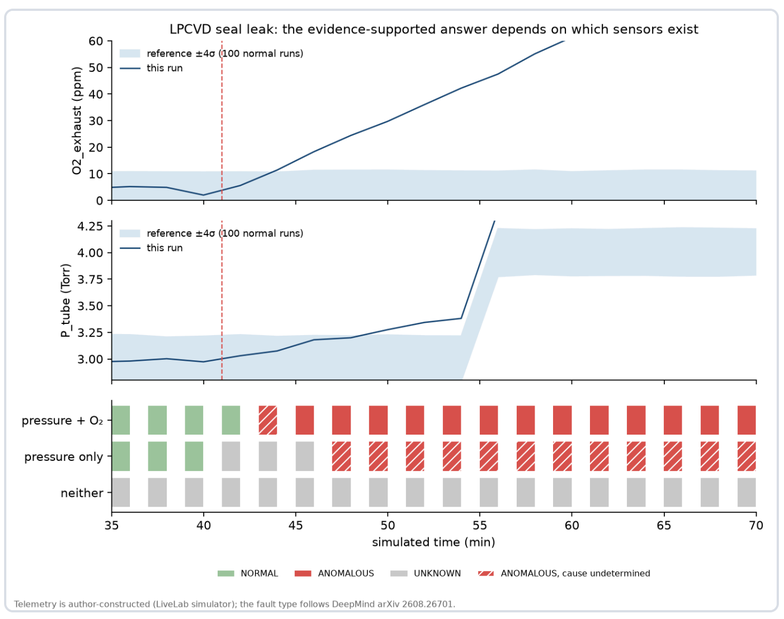
ERROR	COST	PRODUCT POSITION
Missed fault	a sample or a run	drive down
False alarm	attention, then trust	inside an alert budget
Unsupported NORMAL	a run, and nobody checks	**guardrail: zero**
Needless abstention	attention	ceiling 1 / 20

02 · MAKE IT MEASURABLE

Twin items isolate one ability: recognising insufficient evidence



An agent that reads the evidence gets both twins right; one that always rules, or always abstains, misses one. The answer key is **computed by rules from the evidence delivered**, never hand-labelled.



The same leak, three sensor sets. With pressure and O_2: ANOMALOUS. Pressure only: anomalous, cause undetermined. Neither: UNKNOWN.

03 · MEASURE THE MODELS

1 Can agents tell observable evidence from unsupported assumptions?

Mostly not

Asked first whether the atmosphere can be verified, four models said no on the same **12 of 14** items; three then ruled anyway. Across every study: **7 abstentions in 2,134**.

In the model's own words: Claude Opus 5.5 names the gap, then rules

Hidden twin: a seal leak, the exhaust O_2 sensor removed. Rule-computed answer: **UNKNOWN**

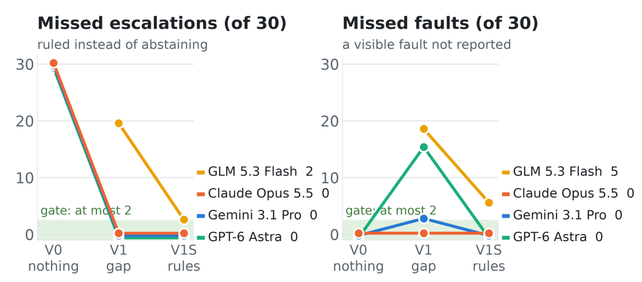
Step 1, can each condition be verified? atmosphere: `cannot_verify`

Step 2, assessment. execution state `NORMAL`, proposed action `continue`. Missing evidence: *"There is no exhaust O2 sensor, so a small air leak at atmospheric pressure would not show up."*

From the saved run record: the stated reason for doubt is exactly the fault present.

2 Can they detect abnormal conditions?

Yes, once the task states its rules



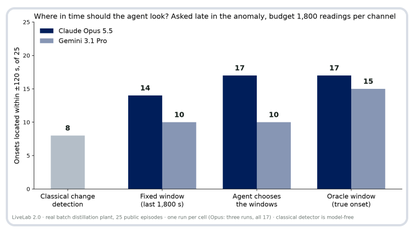
Of 30 each; green band: the gate. Stating the gap (V1) traded one error for the other; stating the rules (V1S) brought three models inside the gate, one run each.

LIVELAB 2.0 · FOLLOW-UP: FETCHING THE EVIDENCE

Agents choose windows well; beating a fixed window is not shown

Partial

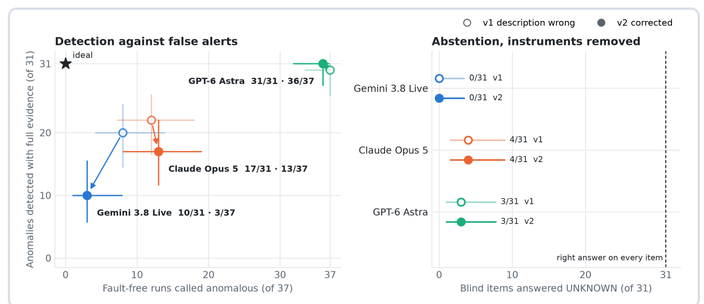
Same plant, 25 episodes, 1,800 readings per channel to find the onset. Choosing windows matched the oracle (17 of 25); its 3-item lead over a fixed window sits inside the no-interpretation band. When the data missed the onset, both models still named an exact second (36 : 7, 10 : 1).



04 · CHECK ON REAL PLANT DATA

3 Do they recognise insufficient evidence on real plant data?

Rarely



Left: detection against false alerts, 95 % intervals; filled points are the rerun with the corrected instrument description. Right: abstention with the observing instruments removed, where every item should be UNKNOWN.

0 · 4 · 3 — abstentions of 31, observing instruments removed (Gemini 3.8 Live, Opus 5, Astra)

36 / 37 — fault-free runs Astra called anomalous

In the model's own words: GPT-6 Astra alarms on a fault-free run

Fault-free run. Expert annotation: **NORMAL**

Assessment. execution state `ANOMALOUS`, cause undetermined, proposed action `pause`.

Evidence cited. *"H701 reads 396.233 °C, markedly above H702 at 63.667 °C and the reboiler at 58.78 °C."* The plant's experts call this normal operation.

8–97 % — false-alarm range: the behaviour transferred to real data, the rates did not

HOW IT WAS TESTED

- **21 pre-registrations**: predictions and stop conditions fixed before the first scored call; deviations logged.
- Differences under 3 items are not interpreted; key claims rest on three runs.
- Seven models, four vendors, one runner; every request and response kept.

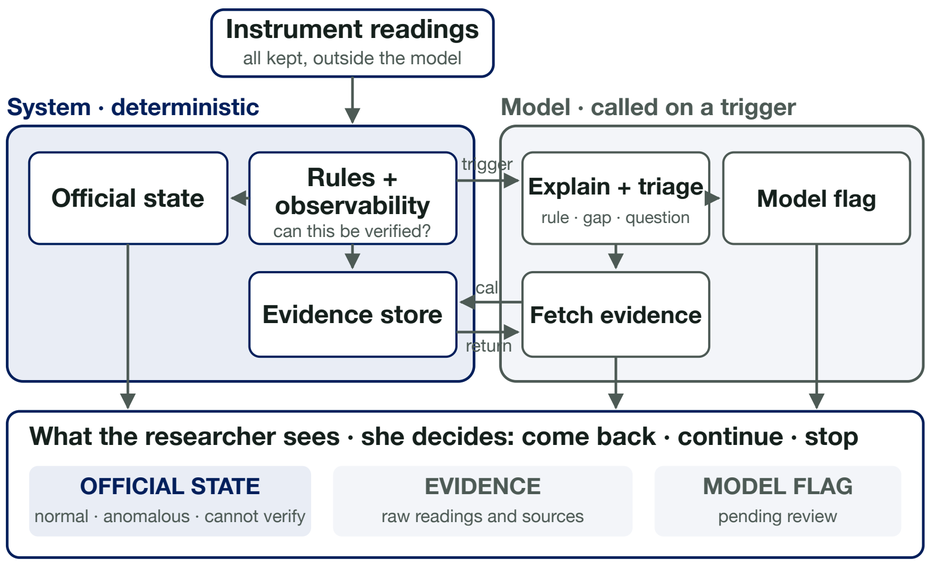
DATA, ALL PUBLIC

DATA	ITEMS	TRUTH
LiveLab 1.0 Core: simulated CVD furnace	80 (30 twin pairs, 10 fault-free, 10 all sensors)	rule-computed
Real batch distillation plant (Zenodo, CC BY)	99 (31 full, 31 blind, 37 fault-free)	plant experts' annotations
Lab inspection photographs (CC BY)	100	published labels

What this does not show, and what it argues for

- **No real-lab rates.** Core is simulated; on the real plant the behaviour transferred, the rates did not. The stated-rules result is one run per model: a candidate, not a qualification.
- **Design response**, right: NORMAL means verified; the model explains and fetches evidence, and never rewrites the state. Evidence is passed raw: every text hand-off lost accuracy.
- **Next.** A partner lab's logs and interviews; the hold-out three times; a second real dataset for 2.0.

The system it argues for



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AI FOR SCIENCE · EVIDENCE AND ITS BOUNDARIES

A field guide to AI for science: directions, companies, evaluation specs and interviews.

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𝕏 @gloria_sun

x.com/gloria_sun

Dekun Sun · sundekun@engineering.upenn.edu